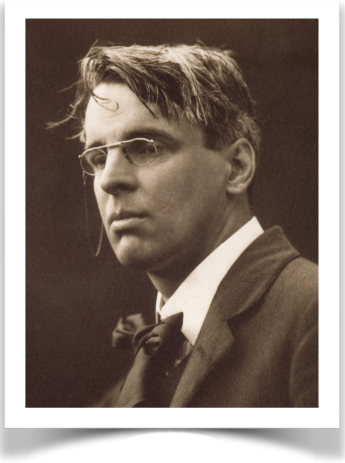
The Second Coming

William Butler Yeats

William Butler Yeats (1865–1939)



William Butler Yeats was one of the greatest poets of the twentieth century and a central figure in modern English literature. Born on **13 June 1865** in Dublin, Ireland, he spent much of his childhood in County Sligo, whose landscapes, folklore, and mythology profoundly influenced his imagination. Yeats was a leading force behind the **Irish Literary Revival**, a movement that sought to revive Irish culture, language, and literary traditions. Along with Lady Gregory and others, he co-founded the **Abbey Theatre** in Dublin, which became Ireland's national theatre and played a vital role in promoting Irish drama.

Yeats's early poetry is marked by romanticism, symbolism, mysticism, and Irish legends, reflecting his fascination with mythology and the supernatural. As he matured, however, his poetry became more direct and intellectually complex, engaging with themes such as politics, history, ageing, violence, and the spiritual condition of humanity. Despite this shift, he continued to explore his lifelong interest in mystical philosophy and his theory of historical cycles.

In recognition of his outstanding literary achievement, Yeats was awarded the **Nobel Prize in Literature** in **1923**, becoming the first Irish writer to receive the honour. He also served as a member of the Irish Senate from 1922 to 1928. His major works include *The Land of Heart's Desire* (1894), *Cathleen ni Houlihan* (1902), *The Wild Swans at Coole*(1919), *The Tower* (1928), and the celebrated poem *The Second Coming*. Yeats's rich poetic legacy continues to influence readers and writers across the world.

About the Poem “The Second Coming”

“The Second Coming” is one of William Butler Yeats's most celebrated and influential poems. Written in **1919** and first published in **1920**, it reflects the widespread uncertainty and disillusionment that followed the devastation of the **First World War** and the political unrest in Ireland and Europe. Rather than presenting the Christian belief in the Second Coming of Jesus Christ as a symbol of hope and salvation, Yeats offers a disturbing vision of a world descending into disorder and violence.

The poem opens with the famous image of a falcon flying farther and farther away from the falconer, suggesting that humanity has lost control and that the established social and moral order is collapsing. Yeats famously declares, "Things fall apart; the centre cannot hold," capturing the sense of chaos that defines the modern world. In the second stanza, the speaker experiences a prophetic vision in which a monstrous, sphinx-like creature slowly emerges

from the desert and moves towards Bethlehem to be born. This terrifying figure replaces the expected return of Christ and symbolizes the arrival of a new and unsettling historical era.

Rich in symbolism, biblical allusions, and apocalyptic imagery, *The Second Coming* explores themes of chaos, violence, historical change, and the decline of civilization. Its powerful language and universal relevance have made it one of the most frequently quoted and widely studied poems in modern English literature.

The Poem "The Second Coming"

Turning and turning in the widening gyre
The falcon cannot hear the falconer;
Things fall apart; the centre cannot hold;
Mere anarchy is loosed upon the world,
The blood-dimmed tide is loosed, and everywhere
The ceremony of innocence is drowned;
The best lack all conviction, while the worst
Are full of passionate intensity.

Surely some revelation is at hand;
Surely the Second Coming is at hand.
The Second Coming! Hardly are those words out
When a vast image out of Spiritus Mundi
Troubles my sight: somewhere in sands of the desert
A shape with lion body and the head of a man,
A gaze blank and pitiless as the sun,
Is moving its slow thighs, while all about it
Reel shadows of the indignant desert birds.
The darkness drops again; but now I know
That twenty centuries of stony sleep
Were vexed to nightmare by a rocking cradle,
And what rough beast, its hour come round at last,
Slouches towards Bethlehem to be born?

The Summary of the Poem

"The Second Coming" presents a powerful vision of a world overwhelmed by chaos and uncertainty in the aftermath of the First World War. The poem is divided into two stanzas. In the **first stanza**, the poet describes a society in which order has collapsed and traditional values have disappeared. Violence, bloodshed, and confusion dominate the world, while good people remain passive and evil forces become increasingly powerful. This sense of moral and social breakdown is captured in the famous line, "Things fall apart; the centre cannot hold."

In the **second stanza**, the speaker anticipates the Christian Second Coming—the return of Jesus Christ—but instead witnesses a frightening prophetic vision. A mysterious creature with

the body of a lion, the head of a man, and a cold, expressionless gaze slowly moves towards Bethlehem. This "rough beast" symbolizes the birth of a new and terrifying age. Through its vivid imagery and apocalyptic tone, the poem reflects Yeats's fear that humanity is entering a period of violence, instability, and profound historical change.

Explanation of Important Lines

"Turning and turning in the widening gyre"

The poem opens with the image of a **widening gyre**, or spiral, which reflects Yeats's belief that history moves in repeating cycles. As the spiral grows wider, it suggests that the world is moving farther away from stability and order. The image symbolizes a civilization that is spinning out of control and entering a new, uncertain phase of history.

"The falcon cannot hear the falconer"

The falcon represents humanity, while the falconer symbolizes God, authority, tradition, or moral guidance. The falcon flying so far away that it can no longer hear its master suggests that people have lost contact with the values and institutions that once guided society. The breakdown of this relationship reflects the collapse of moral and social order.

"Things fall apart; the centre cannot hold"

This is one of the most famous lines in modern English poetry. It expresses the idea that the forces holding society together—such as law, morality, religion, and tradition—have become weak. As a result, civilization begins to collapse, and unity gives way to disorder and conflict.

"Mere anarchy is loosed upon the world"

Yeats describes a world where chaos and lawlessness have spread everywhere. Violence replaces peace, and society descends into confusion. The line reflects the political instability and destruction that followed the First World War and suggests that humanity is entering an age of disorder.

"The ceremony of innocence is drowned"

This line suggests that innocence, purity, and goodness have been overwhelmed by violence and cruelty. The values that once protected human civilization have been destroyed by war, hatred, and moral corruption. It conveys the tragic loss of human compassion.

"The best lack all conviction, while the worst are full of passionate intensity."

Yeats contrasts good and evil in society. He observes that wise and responsible people often remain silent or hesitate to act, while destructive and immoral people are confident, determined, and energetic. This powerful observation remains relevant in modern politics and public life, where extreme voices often dominate while moderate voices remain unheard.

"Surely the Second Coming is at hand"

After witnessing widespread chaos, the speaker initially believes that the Christian Second Coming—the return of Jesus Christ—must be near. Traditionally, Christ's return symbolizes hope, justice, and the restoration of peace. However, Yeats soon overturns this expectation with a shocking vision.

"Spiritus Mundi"

Spiritus Mundi is a Latin phrase meaning **"World Spirit."** Yeats uses it to refer to the collective memory or shared imagination of humanity from which myths, symbols, dreams, and prophetic visions emerge. The frightening image that follows appears to arise from this universal storehouse of human experience.

"A shape with lion body and the head of a man"

The speaker sees a terrifying creature resembling the ancient Egyptian **Sphinx**, with the body of a lion and the head of a man. Its blank and emotionless expression suggests mystery, cruelty, and immense power. Unlike Christ, this figure offers no hope or compassion but represents the arrival of a harsh new civilization.

"Twenty centuries of stony sleep"

The phrase refers to approximately **2,000 years of Christian civilization**, beginning with the birth of Christ. Yeats suggests that this long period has now come to an end and that history is awakening into a completely different era marked by uncertainty and violence.

"What rough beast, its hour come round at last, / Slouches towards Bethlehem to be born?"

These closing lines present one of the most haunting images in modern poetry. Instead of Christ returning to Bethlehem, Yeats imagines a monstrous "rough beast" slowly approaching the same sacred place to be born. The creature symbolizes the birth of a terrifying new age characterized by destruction, violence, and the collapse of traditional values. The poem ends with a question, leaving readers uncertain and anxious about the future of humanity.

Major Themes in the Poem

1. Chaos and Disorder

One of the central themes of the poem is the collapse of order. Yeats presents a world filled with confusion, violence, and instability, where traditional values and institutions have lost their power. Images of anarchy and bloodshed create the impression of a civilization falling apart.

2. The End of Civilization

Yeats suggests that no civilization lasts forever. According to his theory of history, every historical era eventually declines and is replaced by another. The poem implies that the

Christian age, which has lasted for nearly two thousand years, is coming to an end and a new era is about to begin.

3. Good versus Evil

The poem contrasts the weakness of good people with the confidence of evil people. Yeats observes that those who stand for truth and justice often remain silent or inactive, while destructive forces act with determination and passion. This imbalance contributes to the collapse of society.

4. Violence and War

Violence is a dominant theme throughout the poem. Yeats reflects on the devastation caused by the First World War, showing how war destroys innocence, morality, and social harmony. The poem portrays a world overwhelmed by bloodshed and suffering.

5. Fear of the Future

Instead of looking forward to a hopeful future, Yeats imagines the arrival of something frightening. The expected return of Christ is replaced by the vision of a monstrous "rough beast," symbolizing uncertainty, fear, and the possibility of a dark new age.

6. Cyclical Theory of History

The poem reflects Yeats's belief that history moves in recurring cycles rather than in a straight line. Every civilization rises, reaches its peak, and eventually declines before giving way to another. The "rough beast" symbolizes the beginning of a new historical cycle that will replace the old Christian era.

Symbols in the Poem

Symbol	Meaning
Falcon	Humanity; people losing direction
Falconer	God; authority; moral order; tradition
Gyre	Historical cycles; the rise and fall of civilizations
Blood-	War; violence; destruction; chaos
Spiritus	Universal human imagination; collective memory
Sphinx / Rough Beast	A frightening new civilization; destruction; the end of the Christian era
Bethlehem	Birthplace of Christ; symbol of hope and Christianity; its use creates irony as the "rough beast," rather than Christ, approaches it

Literary Devices in the Poem

Symbolism

Yeats makes extensive use of symbolism to convey deeper meanings. Symbols such as the **falcon**, **gyre**, **rough beast**, and **Bethlehem** represent humanity, historical cycles, the rise of a terrifying new age, and the Christian world respectively.

Imagery

The poem contains vivid and powerful imagery that creates a strong visual impression of chaos and destruction. Images such as the **"blood-dimmed tide,"** the **desert**, the **Sphinx-like beast**, and **darkness** intensify its apocalyptic atmosphere.

Biblical Allusion

Yeats draws on the Bible by referring to the **Second Coming of Christ**, **Bethlehem**, and the **Book of Revelation**. These allusions create expectations of salvation, which the poem dramatically overturns.

Irony

The poem employs irony by leading readers to expect the return of Christ as a symbol of hope and redemption. Instead, the speaker witnesses the arrival of a terrifying "rough beast," suggesting fear and destruction rather than peace.

Repetition

The repetition of the word **"Surely"** emphasizes the speaker's growing expectation that the Second Coming is near. It also builds suspense before the shocking vision is revealed.

Rhetorical Question

The poem concludes with the famous question, **"What rough beast... slouches towards Bethlehem to be born?"**Rather than providing an answer, Yeats leaves readers with uncertainty and anxiety about the future, reinforcing the poem's mysterious and unsettling tone.

Multiple Choice Questions

1. "The Second Coming" was written by W. B. Yeats in the aftermath of:

A. The French Revolution
B. The First World War
C. The Second World War
D. The Irish Potato Famine

2. In the poem, the "falcon" primarily symbolizes:

A. Nature
B. Humanity
C. Christianity
D. The poet himself

3. What does the line "Things fall apart; the centre cannot hold" suggest?

A. Society is becoming more united.
B. Civilization is collapsing and order is breaking down.
C. Nature is returning to its original state.
D. Peace has finally been restored.

4. The phrase Spiritus Mundi refers to:

A. The Kingdom of Heaven
B. A mythical kingdom
C. The collective memory and imagination of humanity
D. The Roman Empire

5. The "rough beast" in the poem symbolizes:

A. The return of Christ
B. Hope and redemption
C. A terrifying new historical age
D. The triumph of Christianity

6. Which of the following is a major theme of “The Second Coming”?

A. Romantic love and beauty
B. Nature and pastoral life
C. Chaos, violence, and the collapse of civilization
D. Adventure and heroism

7. The poem ends with a rhetorical question about the "rough beast" slouching towards Bethlehem. What is the effect of this ending?

A. It provides a clear solution to the world's problems.
B. It celebrates the return of peace and harmony.
C. It leaves readers with uncertainty and a sense of fear about the future.
D. It confirms that Christ has already returned.

Answer Key

1. B; 2. B; 3. B; 4. C; 5. C; 6. C; 7. C.

Short Answer Questions

1. Explain the symbolic significance of the falcon and the falconer in “The Second Coming”
Hint: Falcon = humanity; Falconer = God, authority, and moral guidance; explain how their separation symbolizes the breakdown of order.

2. What is meant by *Spiritus Mundi*? How does it contribute to the meaning of the poem?
Hint: A Latin phrase meaning "World Spirit"; represents the collective human imagination from which the speaker's vision arises.

3. Why is “The Second Coming” considered a prophetic poem?
Hint: It predicts the end of one historical age and the arrival of a new and frightening era rather than Christ's peaceful return.

4. How does Yeats portray the collapse of order and civilization in the opening stanza?
Hint: Refer to the widening gyre, the falcon losing contact with the falconer, "Things fall apart," anarchy, and the blood-dimmed tide.

5. Describe the "rough beast" and explain its symbolic significance.
Hint: A Sphinx-like creature that symbolizes violence, the collapse of old values, and the birth of a terrifying new civilization.

6. Discuss any two literary devices used by Yeats in “The Second Coming,” giving suitable examples.

Hint: Choose any two: symbolism (falcon, gyre), imagery ("blood-dimmed tide"), biblical allusion (Second Coming, Bethlehem), irony, repetition ("Surely"), or rhetorical question (final lines).

Essay Questions

1. "The Second Coming" presents a disturbing vision of a world overwhelmed by chaos and uncertainty. Discuss how Yeats explores the themes of **chaos, violence, and the collapse of civilization** in the poem.

Hint: Discuss the historical background (post-First World War), the imagery of disorder, "Things fall apart; the centre cannot hold," anarchy, bloodshed, and the symbolic "rough beast."

2. Examine the use of **symbolism and biblical allusion** in "The Second Coming." How do these literary devices contribute to the poem's meaning?

Hint: Explain symbols such as the falcon, falconer, gyre, blood-dimmed tide, Spiritus Mundi, the rough beast, and Bethlehem, along with the biblical references to the Second Coming and the Book of Revelation.

3. Discuss Yeats's concept of **cyclical history** in *The Second Coming*. How does the poem present the end of one historical age and the beginning of another?

Hint: Explain Yeats's theory of the gyre, the decline of the Christian era, the significance of "twenty centuries of stony sleep," and the symbolic birth of the "rough beast" as the beginning of a new historical cycle.